

DRAFT

On reality:

Essay 1: Introduction to Reality

In the following series of essays, I will elaborate upon my perspective on reality.

Reality is studied under the field of ontology—that being the study of that which exists, or more formally, the study of "being." To be is to exist, as Hamlet referenced in his musings on suicide. Some may see reality as synonymous with the universe, but of course, that is non-inclusive of many schools of thought, wrong or right.

Why study reality?

Well, it is pure practicality. Anything that is real, from a chair, a cell, a computer to a jackhammer, person, or cat, is under study.

We all constantly study reality. Though we do not always frame it as such.

Models, concepts, schemata.

While it is true that since the dawn of philosophical inquiry people have searched for universal abstractions to describe the state of affairs of all things. People generalize in their own lives just like philosophers.

We all carry stories, narratives, and explanations to elucidate the workings of our world.

For example, we all feel certain pangs within our body and think:

"I am hungry" or "I need food."

These are statements from assumptions or models about the world. They are implicitly contentions about how the world exists. We argue there is an "I" that is connected to this feeling. That "I" needs something. This feeling means something. We have provided an explanation for physical body signals. In other words, we have utilized our models of reality to derive an explanation of the situation. We have effectively provided a rule: x means y. That itself is a primitive theory of the world. Perhaps a more complex theory might explain the biochemical cascade and remove the abstraction of hunger into a more mechanistic explanation, but that was not needed pragmatically. And as such, our ideas, or schemata, acclimated to the needs of the environment.

We can see that with superior explanations of events, we can often derive superior knowledge for action. With a better comprehension of medicine, one can understand how to fix their own body. With a better understanding of a car, they may do more to take care of their car and not get robbed.

You can also see, in an interpersonal encounter, one person may offend another, or they may engage in a way that is confusing. Both parties then propose an explanation or use a model to elaborate their view of the reality of the situation. The search for truth is pervasive.

I like to fancy myself as a person obsessed with uncovering what's real. To do this, I will often examine my first assumption (e.g. I am hungry) and try to do one better and explain it on some deeper more mechanistic level.

I may rest my hand on a table and first thing. "This table is solid" then I said, but I know it is mostly empty space. And I probe further and further. Until I exhaust my ability to examine from lack of explanation or lethargy.

What I'm doing is simply philosophy, which effectively allows one to ask endlessly (more on philosophy and its nature later).

I have had a good deal of fun over the course of my over ten years of examining these subjects. And I thought I'd share them.

My views of the world revolve around the nature of knowledge, the mind, and the physical principles of reality as a whole. I often strive to know more, read more, learn more. But it takes time. So here we go.

Essay 2: Reality Orientation

We have established in the first essay that philosophers, academics, and the layperson effectively do the same thing: pursue reality so as to navigate it.

It is often noted that humans are bound by narratives. Explanations in the form of stories. But why is that? Well, that is, as might be expected, what we can refer to as reality orientation.

There is, within all of us, a need to make sense of the world. We all need to be pointed towards explanations of the world that can organize our mind and behaviors. I will make light of this later, but I contend the purpose of the mind is to allow for movement. And a clear mind allows us to move with the knowledge of the abstract details of our reality.

Instead of seeing a person rage over an event without thought, we impose a context, or an explanation of its reality to allow us to know how to behave in kind.

Therefore, human beings need to seek reality for coherence to facilitate movement.

Without the history of human thought narratives like these allowed us to explain our relationships (child, wife, husband, cousin), our political structures (president, senator, king, pharaoh, chief, servant), our explanations of spirituality (god, angels, gods, souls, afterlife) our knowledge of cycles of nature (weather, climate, seasons, sleep/wake) of our goals (to love, to work, to eat) and explanations of our body signals (need to go to bathroom, to eat, sleepiness). Can you imagine what we would do without these explanations. They say with a why you can pursue any how? But what if you never had a why. If you lived purely in the moment without reference to any moment. What if you did not understand what your body wished to tell you? Or the concept of who is your child, and why you are so attached to your partner.

Dizzying right?

And so, I obsess. Because I believe that if our explanations of reality improve, so do our strategies to better impact our lives. Beyond that I also find the pursuit to be quite enjoyable. There is something fun about imposing your imagination on the world and seeing its accurate to what exists. Wouldn't you say it is satisfying to understand the motives of another person, or perhaps the reason for why an eclipse occurs. So alright. I've made my case that pursuing what is real. Is something we all do. And with that we introduce philosophy. That is the art of doing this right.

Essay 3: Philosophy as a Tool

Philosophers love defining things. Some would say it's actually most of what they do. And some philosophers love defining philosophers. Some even enjoy studying the philosopher who defines philosophy. And others study those who study the people who study those that define philosophical terms. In this absurd meta hierarchy I place myself near the bottom.

So what is philosophy?

Well, the answer is that it depends on the tiers. Some ask questions offhandedly and, from substance inducement, quickly forget what they asked. Others dwell on a specific question for much of their lives. It can be argued that they both engage in philosophy, but only the latter sees the full process.

The process?

I contend philosophy is less of a subject and more of a tool. And that the purpose of this tool is to pursue the most general features within a given system of inquiry. To pursue philosophy is to find grand patterns within data. And then, as is often the case, to refer to that pattern by a name.

E.g. What are these people doing with their legs? It seems to always happen.

I shall refer to that process of traveling from point a to point b as "movement". And the thing they are doing with their legs, as "walking"

You might say: um. We already know those terms.

Me: correct. And the process of deriving them is philosophy.

In the olden days, philosophers looked like men in togas harassing random women in markets searching for fresh fish but these days philosophers are more well adjusted. Often with salaries and houses.

These days we often have philosophies of a thing. There are :

Philosophies of religion - discussing the way religion is done, what are its core beliefs. And the ramifications.

Philosophies of companies—what are the principles that the company follows as it pertains to how it engages with its workers, and how it defines its mission statement and vision?

Philosophy of physics - is the world deterministic or probabilistic ? What is mass? Force? Time?

These philosophical ideas don't just define patterns, but also extrapolate narratives , or theories , and advance our schemata.

So how has the philosopher elevated the everyday persons reality orientation process?

Answer:

-by imposing rules of thought as to what is and is not a good idea.

- by refining concepts to make them more appropriate to the system being observed .

- By allowing for increased practicality

Essay 4: Philosophy Done Right

It is said that an idea can obfuscate, or illuminate the truth. Such an idea of this was noted within Karl Mannheim's ideology and utopia regarding propaganda . In his eyes ideas floating around in the social ether can bring us close or away from knowing the real world. This is an astute observation . And one that is quite important in the sociology of knowledge. For our case it is important for understanding how close an idea is to being aligned with what is real. A person's notions can help or hinder philosophical pursuits.

But how do we know in what direction we are moving:

Yes, I'm once again asserting there is something to move towards.

The study of knowing what is or is not real, and how we verify is called epistemology. It is one of the primary branches of the formal study of philosophy.

This leads to the question of how we can distinguish the real from the imagined.

Well there is an old debate as to how to tell if something is real or not. It basically comes down to logic or sensation.

Many say that for much of history people relied most on what they could think when inferring about the world. Everyone followed a logical sequence, as the world is causal. And logic follows similar trains of reasoning embedded in the logic of time. This, then this.

While one can use logic to infer quite a bit about the world. There is an issue: there is no safeguard to the imagination.

People have proposed many ideas that logically one could argue that each time no one is looking that fairies appear and are dancing behind them. And that no detection device like a camera or eyeballs can perceive it. Could I argue against? No.

But some also say that "an absence of evidence is not evidence of absence." Which is fine. However there are times in history where people have found mathematical evidence for something which has not been shown yet to exist. So clearly as math behaves within the confines of one of many species of logic, that rationalizing can produce the true.

Limitations and decisions :

It is at this moment that I must make a confession. There is no iron clad model of reality. It is impossible to make a complete coherent absolutely true model of the real world. This is something many may find quite troubling. At times, you need to do the uncomfortable : and make decisions. Why do we know that empiricism is superior to rationalism? Well because we have decided that at the core, that which comes through the senses is more real. And why is it more real than logic? Because it repeats itself. The senses occur again and we can later create models of reality to explain the order of things that impact our senses. As in science.

Why is it that repeatability is a proof of realness? Such a question may sound absurd to the modern mind. But it is not. It is because we have decided that which is real is that which persists through sensory impact. That is a decision .

As such philosophy is laden with these decisions . We have many moments where we have to accept the benefits and perils of a framework. And establish our epistemically foothold.

In practical terms, establishing truth involves a clear process:

1. we decide upon our epistemology
2. We follow the rules or logic

Now logic is a funny one . As one need to buy into the laws of logic. And say something must be true because it adheres to this system. And I agree with these rules. Which of course requires logic to even do so. So your commitment to logic seems obvious.

It is not.

So here we are artificially accepting an epistemic ground. And a structure of reasoning from that floor to sustain something as "true".

It is actually quite irritating when you think about it. And for this reason many likely will avoid doing that. Of course then we have the funny situation where logical, does not mean reasonable. So we need to affirm an even deeper means of logic. But more on that later.

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Anyway, I will proceed to describe reality as I understand it. To do that, I will establish my footing. I understand that on a level of extreme skepticism, I can reject all I know and feel doubt for everything. Descartes famously rejected the world with the exception of his thoughts in his "cogito ergo sum."

I however am not bogged down that reality orientation is a decision. And I apply the pragmatic school of thought by saying that the reality I am most oriented to is that which my senses can reach. And within that we have a great deal of caveats as to what that means more precisely.

Now I should mention, for the peace to some. I do not reject that rationality can produce unseen worlds. As I mentioned above. Theoretical physics has shown logic often before experience . Such as in the discovery of the Higgs Boson in the Large Hadron Collider , or the verification of the distortion of light by gravity in general relativity in 1919 in South America. Other sciences do the same. As such we can arrive at some hypothesis about what might be.

However, not all speculations about unseen worlds deserve equal credibility from a practical perspective even if technically , it is reasonable to apply the Popperian concept of what is and is not science. That being what can and can not be verified. And I shall say. For claims I can not test. I put in the bucket of uncertainty. Though of course, one is permitted to accept what they like. But they must always understand the simple truth : truth implies framework.

From the perspective of finance and industry it is clear that not all frameworks are equally adaptive . That should be self-evident. But of course , perhaps within your framework that is acceptable .

These in short. Are the rules of thought.

(Please see the bottom of the essay to see a dialogue on the nature of “decision “ and the nature of truth and logic)

Essay 5: Sensation as Truth

Above I established that I adhere to empiricism and to logic. To be “true” within my framework something must be able to be interacted by with human senses. Logic is utilized as a scaffold to make inferences and theories. And thus we can learn what is true within these parameters. To be true, it must be observable. For peer-review it must be repeatable.

On the birth of the world.

Now that I have established how to define true. I can start building my perspective .

The empirical framework of epistemology -and its accompanying logical structures - has been institutionalized , and industrialized into the modern scientific establishment. We see, then we devise theory logically. And we see once again if the theory is true .

Science has wrought a great deal of fruit. It has uncovered myriad of secrets that we could not have known without modeling and observation.

A few essays ago I introduced the notion of a primitive reality orientation that humans have to be able to navigate a world so complex that its details are only parsed out through broad generalizations strewn together in a story.

Science utilizes these narratives. Otherwise known as models or theories, and frames them as a hypothesis and tests if they are true based on confirmation between the story and the observation. Then later they are called theories or laws (a grandiose term).

Let us refine what we are looking to express in these series of essays as an answer to what is reality. And in particular to what my proposed answer is:
the greatest and most understandable story, with the highest truth value.

So science is the answer ?

In my empirical framework science is indeed a necessary component. But we are not full of all the answers. So let us return to the history of philosophy.

Essay 6: The Forbearers

The history of philosophy has produced concepts with variable levels of quality. Within epistemology , there are been quite a few good ones. To understand my worldview it is important to enter the right mindset. By learning the ideas of a few thinkers and combining them.

1. Plato's allegory of the cave,
2. The cogito
3. Bacon, Galileo, Newton
4. Berkeley
5. Kant's thing-in-itself
6. Schopenhauer's representation
7. Modern neuroscience and physics

These 7 ideas exist within a historical lineage of doubt and truth. And within my ideas work together within the empirical -scientific framework of epistemology.

The cave

The Foundation of Epistemology:

Plato's metaphysics posits that forms, or the shapes of things, are made from fundamental patterns. What appears to the eyes to be a chaotic mess of trees, water, rocks, buildings, and cars is all just instantiations of pure structures. Understanding his forms is quite difficult; I contend they are much more complex than what modern scholars understand. Perhaps that is simply speculation. However, for the purpose of this essay, commenting on the nature of the forms is less important than understanding the nature of what people carelessly call "objective reality."

Not one sensible person. Reasonable thinker doubts that perception is a good place to start. Plato discusses the nature of what's real in his cave.

A bunch of people stare at a wall. And they are shackled . And they, behind them have a fire burning. They can see the shadows the fire casts as it perfumes its dance of binding with oxygen. If they did not know much of the world it would be reasonable to assume the shadows on the wall are acting in their own accord. Without knowledge of the fire , they see the shadows on the wall. To them that is all there is.

To Plato, that is what we see . We see but shaddows on the wall. That the world is not what it appears and we only see the shadows of the truth.

At the core what Plato demonstrates is that our eyes do not see the real world . Some refer to the belief that our eyes see the true nature of the world as naive realism. It all be made clear that I am quite opposed to that position. Socrates , a teacher of Plato, and a character in his writings states a true skeptic “all I know is I know nothing” so what is real according to Plato ? Plato shrugs.

The cogito

Many years after the death of Plato, and his entire civilization. And after the death of civilizations after him in the 1500-1600s AD we find within France one of the great epistemology thinkers on the history of humanity. Rene Descartes. While his contributions to human thought are numerous. It is for my purpose to note upon his cogito.

Descartes in line with Plato accepted that our reality is not self evident. That we do not know what is real. It is not our inheritance to connect to this truth. In his meditations he rejected all he knew and tried to build from first principles. And he stated his famous line “cogito ergo sum” . Translated as “I think therefore I am”. Upon rejected all truth. Descartes decides that the only think he knows is that he is thinking. Some modern thinkers reflecting on the concept of qualia like to say “I feel therefore I am” . And there are disputes as to if Descartes would agree. With that position . However that does not matter here.

The point of the matter is Descartes accepted uncertainty of all thing. Yet he positions his perspective . As that he is thinking. And he can see himself thinking. And therefore the thinker who reflects upon his own thought must exist. I contend this loop is more clever than some neuroscientists realize. The mind grasps that the mind is grasping. And to do that it must be real . Plato states our world is real, but we do not see it clearly and Descartes states that what we see is a lie but what we think must be real.

Bacon Galileo newton

Science - or as it used to be called - natural philosophy, was one of the great innovations of history .the notion that not only is sensation real, but that we should impose models or concepts on the world and observe to see if those concepts represent the world- is brilliant.

The early scientists were mostly naive realists. They were not bothered by if reality represented what is true as much as they were in figuring out the shape form and patterns of the world .

They devised exact patterns which represented the world . Enough so that the patterns describe the world perfectly within some limited domain. Such as predicting how some perceived feature of the world will move under specific conditions , and how certain details of the world were cosmic such as space time and gravity. It is not with science that we verify what is real. But that patterns can be explained . Through this thought process and method we learned that even if we can't see what is real, we can devise patterns with concepts to discover nonetheless.

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Berkeley.

It is around the time of Newton that George Berkeley stepped on the scene. He in particular had some quite interesting observations. For him we do not see the world that the scientists were investigating. But that Plato's shadows and Descartes cogito were relatable. He posited that our minds create the world. Many years later people would distort his concepts in the brain in a vat thought experiment championed by the matrix. Now it would be absurd to propose the world scientists investigate is not real. But his view was more complex it is that the mind forms our world. We do not see. The mind creates its own views of the world. In a sense you could say that the mind hallucinates the world. That it interacts with the world, but in a manner that is hallucinatory. He in a sense measures the trajectory of the cannon.

Kant's the thing in itself

Kant was quite the synthesizer. In a sense you can see him as the intersection between Berkeley and the scientists. The famous creator of the first dictionary of the English language in the 18th century Samuel Johnson once famously mocked Berkeley's idea of reality being made by the mind by ostensibly kicking an object in an attempt to stub his toe and stated "I refute it thusly". Kant was in the right mind. He was a man well versed in the science of his era. Newton of course being a great influence. Kant would dare not reject what it is the scientists studied. But he was compelled by Berkeley. He was in agreement with Johnson rejecting the absolute position that our mind is the absolute creator of the world. A notion later termed solipsism. An extreme lonely view held by no one sensible. He rather argued that while reality was constructed in our minds, it was, like Plato once claimed, the shadow of the real. So what was real? Plato did not know. None of them did. Even if Descartes had an answer, one need not agree. Kant decided that whatever it was that was making the shadows. The real source, was coined "the thing in it self". Of course he said that in German. So we use a translation.

The thing.

In itself.

As in the mind constructs the thing. By taking aspects of the thing. And making shadows. But there is a thing. That is itself not a representation. But it is pure. That is what is real. Thus what was born is called German idealism. The idea originated in Germany that reality is "an idea". Something we elaborate on later with Schopenhauer. Kant further had contentions that quite a lot was in our minds. More than we might realize like our construct of space and time. He was prescient. However cognitive neuroscientists found evidence that he was correct in the 70s. Many did not know he ever said anything. Some do of course. More on this later.

Schopenhauer

Einstein had 3 photos on his wall. One of Newton, the dual creator of calculus and discoverer of gravity in normal conditions, Maxwell the mathematician of explaining the behavior of electromagnetism- making Faraday's ideas operational, and Schopenhauer. He is said to have a worn out copy of Schopenhauer's magnum opus the world as Will and representation. The quantum theorist Heisenberg who helped introduce probability on a world reigned by determinism, also was deeply inspired by many were. Why is that? And why is he relevant to us. Schopenhauer was a great thinker of science but one of his two core concepts, representation, is most important to us. While Kant acknowledged that the world was

constructed. Schopenhauer advanced the concept. He started his famous book "the world is my representation" that the essence of the world is that it is a parallel reality to the thing in itself. In his frame, to have an object, there must be a subject; to have a subject, there must be an object. When one speaks of something, they don't speak of the thing-in-itself; they speak of a model.

In essence Schopenhauer stated the implications of German idealism is that we interface with a representation of the world.

In modern terms you could say he introduced the notion of "user interface" just as when you interact with your phone you are engaging with complex circuits and code you can not see, and only see something friendly that's easy to interact with. Just as you do not need to understand circuits to see phones or computers and move your mouse. We see an interface.

But it is more akin to virtual reality. A user interface we can move around in. An object is like an asset. The graphics seem great. But the resolution is quite poor.

Modern neuroscience and physics

The resolution is quite poor. There was long ago a view that we see what exists. That idea never died. It has lived since the dawn of thought. When pointing to a rock. This is a rock. As I mentioned in an earlier essay. Statements of definition are the start of philosophy. And it would be silly for a normal person to say "hey is this user interface". It's a non intuitive position that could draw one into either curiosity or crisis. The position of naive realism effectively sees the eyes as able to see the world. Our aforementioned epistemological thinkers have rejected this view one way or another. For most mentioned above, there was a rejection of perception being accurate. The scientists also entertained that life was not how it seemed.

But this view that we see the world clearly. Existed outside of our tradition of hesitation towards accepting perception.

One can take one of many approaches to tell it does not make so much sense. For starters young people like to always comment "objects are made of mostly empty space". Something mentioned in a previous essay off handedly. And someone well versed in chemistry and physics may talk of how all material reality consists of electrons moving back and forth between objects flowing constantly. Dancing. And photons bounce off of atoms. We can learn of the Higgs field and the nature of these forces. How would the world look if we could see the space within all atoms, and observe how all actions involve the dance of electrons moving between atoms. Some systems are more stable and others more erratic. We know this reality. And we know that energy travels between objects and that objects- mass- are in essence energy moving slowly turning into tiny things, with these insane looking solar systems. The atom, as understood after the Bohr model. But look what we see. It is all sturdy. We can not view the porous items. Or see the various spectrums of light. Or the waves or matter that move between our phones. They appear to work invisibly. Same with WiFi. And yet some of us believe.. that we see the real world?

Upon the brain.

To understand the mechanics of sight, we must look beyond the simple act of looking. What I can comment upon is the brain.

What I can comment about is on the brain.

The brain works through the electrical changes within its cells triggering other cells to have an electrical change.

A nerve is hit, or a chemical attaches to it, and under certain conditions, an electrical impulse travels across its membrane. The brain has quite a few neurons, and each neuron can have up to 10,000 connections, triggering a cascade of activity across the entire network. How does thinking happen when it's all just a thing that hits a thing that hits a thing?

Let us think what the brain does. It allows for us to see, to move, to feel.

Now let's imagine a bundle of wires. Electricity fires through one. And another and another. And what do you have? A bunch of wires shooting electricity. But that bundle of electricity can't see anything. But you may say they don't have eyes. But eyes are but balls attached to neurons. Which hit other neurons. And they hit other neurons. Which hit other ones. There is not a hole in the eye that sees. There is a neuron. That hits another neuron. There is not a hole in the ear. But it does not go into the mind. It hits a neuron. And they hit other neurons. Yet for some reason we can think. Joe does thinking happen when it's all just a thing that hits a thing that hits a thing.

For our sake, we are discussing reality.

From an engineering perspective, accepting that ear holes don't go into the mind. It triggers neurons. And eye holes don't enter the mind purely. We are stuck. With this puzzle. How can this bundle of stuff hitting one another create reality?

In the naive view, as mentioned we have holes in our head where reality enters. Yet we see, it is just a bunch of cells triggering one another through electricity.

Remember how Schopenhauer started his book, "the world is my representation" and what is a representation? The user interface. The brain does not see. It represents. In essence it acts on its own accord. And reshapes itself. The wires, rewire. It is alive. The user interface is generative. As one would see in the modern AI parlance. Through its ability to reconfigure its geometry it represents the world. Not from seeing it. But because the neurons get hit. Over and over again. Patterned wise. And the brain acts chaotically. And it begins to create shapes. And patterns. It does not see the holes in matter. It sees something continuous. It does not see. It builds. And the building, its shapes and patterns do not need to be like "the thing in itself". It creates the shadows in the cave. It uses the patterns of neurons getting hit, and hitting other neurons. And then the interface appears.

My iPhone does not look like transistors. My world does not look like neurons. Or perhaps in some way it does?

What we know is that the neurons work together and create the object, within the principles of its own structure.

A brief dialogue

Empiricist: When you say.. why sensing is more true than logic. You say what is true. And then you say what is true is what is real. What is real? Then you say what is repeatable.

Skeptic:

Why does repeatability make it because it's persistent. Why does something persistent make it real?

Empiricist:

Because truth is what is persisting. Because realness is what persists.

Skeptic:

Why is it real what persists?

Empiricist:

Because that makes the most sense.

Skeptic:

Why?

Empiricist:

Because if something is here one second and then another, that is what is real because it persists.

Skeptic:

So the truth is what persists?

Empiricist:

Yes .

Skeptic:

How do you know?

Empiricist:

Because I know.

Skeptic:

So you defined truth as what persists .

Empiricist:

Yes, can you define it any other way? What would you say is what happens once. Or that perception isn't real, what does that even mean ?

Skeptic:

Yes . But you define truth based on what you see.

Empiricist:

But if I don't define it based on what I see than what can be real?

Skeptic: But you do not see god. He does not persist. So is he real?

Skeptic:

I don't know. I don't see my father this second.

Empiricist:

Yes but you have seen your father.

Skeptic:

Sure

Empiricist:

so you're admitting that persistence is true aren't you?

Skeptic:

Maybe but I think you're limiting your definition of truth only to the empirical domain.

Empiricist:

Well I never said that. I merely said that what exist in front of me and does so again is real. And real is just the word for actually existing.

Skeptic:

But don't you realize that you defined parameters of what is real within your already existing framework.

Empiricist:

Ok, but that's the only way to do it not.
You're just playing a game of semantics here .

Skeptic:

Correct. Because at the end of the day we must define truth. And when we define it. We accept a framework . And in doing that. We create our operational definition. We DECIDE our philosophical outlook

Empiricist:

Your game of semantics ignores the self-evident reality of perception. Of Descartes, Plato, Berkeley, science... and all those mentioned earlier by the writer . There is no precedent for your game to say it is all semantics .

Skeptic:

I do not agree. Even the notion of the real is a construct . It is a concept. And it is validated by your conditions . As I have said . You can not escape that philosophy defines, as in creates a frame, and that exists within that frame.

Empiricist:

Sir, without words there is experience. One can silence their concepts and still exist within the real.

Skeptic:

Once again, you resort to your construct . You cannot escape that. You must riddle that you are existing within a tautology.

Empiricist:

You reject reality.

Skeptic:

And you neglect that your epistemic ground relies on your own notions . Did you not notice that Descartes after rejecting all that he decided to take a position. That his thoughts are the only thing he could be sure of .

Empiricist:

That is because they are self-evident. It irritates me that you walk past this. And you claim I "create the world ". How can you say experience isn't real.. sorry I'll avoid the word real as it triggers you. You just. Don't accept any sensible epistemological system. To adhere to an epistemic position is to establish that there must be TRUTH.

Skeptic:

I do not reject the truth. I reject that we can know what is true. In fact . I must admit a secret . I agree with your framework. Surprised ?

Empiricist:

Well. Mostly annoyed that you waste my time. Why did you say all this junk?

Skeptic:

Because I think you miss the fundamental concept in argumentation. That we must when arguing. That this word means this. And that word means that. That truth can only be when it is in this form. I do hold indeed that the empirical world exists. But I must remind you of my position. Logic. Intellectual argumentation does not have givens. It is an abstract system of showing that which exists given certain assumptions . You do not have assumptions before you argue. And whether you begin listing your axioms and definitions or not. You make assumptions about a particular system .

Empiricist:

But the world is not an argument. It exists .

Skeptic:

You .. seem to be. Not hearing me. To understand is to grasp a concept. Now people in history have played around with this notion of “concept” and this notion of “logic” and reasoning process. How in essence you use logic to arrive at truths.

But sir. You don’t use logic to arrive at truth. You use them to discover consequences from your concepts , or assumptions .

Empiricist:

Hrm. So you’re not saying . I don’t have experience .

Skeptic:

Such a position would be absurd .

Empiricist:

You’re arguing What when we think we assume ?

Skeptic:

In part. Language is quite an interesting artifact. Sounds are references. Or shall I say. Sounds in the form of language are representations of the world . Not the world . I say for example that I am holding an apple. But I have defined the concept of my perception. When I speak. I assume . When I assume. I define. When I define I create . When I argue for the truth of a thing- as in use epistemic reasoning. I actually define what is my epistemic ground. I define how I know , how to know . What it means to know the actual .

Empiricist:

But to contend that perceptual experience can even be argued to be sensibly less reasonable than any other framework seems to be to absurd

Skeptic:

Let me reframe your position. It is not absurd. It is not what you consider reasonable with your existing epistemic framework.

Empiricist:

Not what I consider readable is reasonable .

Skeptic:

You are trapped within your frame of analysis . You are being logical. Yes. But you do not attend to the nature of that logic. You agree to definitions, or create, you agree to what follows. Or you apply the logic conventionally used . And there are quite a few forms of logic I should add. Non monotonic for example. And then you exist within your world view. You are trapped in your concepts and their consequences .

Empiricist:

Hrm I will not disagree. But I am ok with that.

The writer:

To understand philosophy you must understand how it works. To truly understand the nature of thought. You must understand how thought parallels the world. It is not the world. This is the architecture of our cultural notions, and personal convictions.

We engage in reality orientation when we exist within our definitions. Philosophy is meant to pressure test our concepts and reality orientation. It is a tool. Of self awareness . To be a philosopher you must know the game you play. And how you participate

